

10 DELHI-MEERUT EXPRESSWAY
96 km

8 DELHI-SAHARANPUR-DEHRADUN EXPRESSWAY
210 km (Delhi to Dehradun via Baghpat, Saharanpur)

9 GHAZIPUR-BALLIA-MANJHIGHAT EXPRESSWAY
117 km (Ghazipur, UP, to Manjhighat, Bihar; to be linked with Purvanchal Expressway)

11 GORAKHPUR-SILIGURI EXPRESSWAY
519 km
Construction yet to start

12 NOIDA-GREATER NOIDA EXPRESSWAY
24 km (Noida to Agra)
Project completed

Graphic by ASIT ROY

a doable longish drive, a boost to tourism is expected. Anticipating this, the state tourism department was asked to prepare detailed plans, and has come up with a package that showcases caves, forts, eco-tourism and adventure sports. Sunil Kumar, professor, Institute of Tourism and Hotel Management at Bundelkhand University, says, "Bundelkhand is a bit unexplored in terms of tourism but it includes many heritage sites in Mahoba, Chitrakoot, Orcha and other places."

GANGA EXPRESSWAY

After its completion, the 594 km Ganga Expressway could rightfully be called an 'artery'. The proposed expressway will start from NH 334 near Bijauli village in Meerut district and terminate on NH 19, near Judapur Dandu village in Prayagraj district. Once complete, it would be the longest highway in the state. The Uttar Pradesh cabinet met at Prayagraj, venue of the Kumbh Mela, and gave the go ahead for the expressway in January 2019. The project aims to construct an access-controlled eight-lane expressway running along the Ganga. It will cover 12 districts—Meerut, Hapur, Bulandshahr, Amroha, Sambhal, Badaun, Shahjahanpur, Hardoi, Unnao, Rae Bareilly, Pratapgarh and Prayagraj—and thus connect east and west UP. The foundation stone was laid by PM Modi in Shahjahanpur on December 18, 2021. The expressway will also link the northern districts in western UP with Meerut, which is linked to NCR through the Delhi-Meerut Expressway. The project is expected to be complete by 2025.

Other notable road projects of Uttar Pradesh are within the remit of the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI). Among these, the Lucknow-Kanpur expressway project is considered important. According to N.N. Giri, project director, NHAI (Lucknow zone), "Construction will start in October 2022 and will take two and a half years to complete. Travel time from Lucknow to Kanpur will be reduced to 45 minutes, from one and a half hours."

According to Awanish Awasthi, additional chief secretary, home, and CEO of UPIEDA, "Expressways are the backbone of infrastructure and tourism development. The chief minister wanted us to connect districts in Purvanchal and Bundelkhand, which are considered backward, with the other parts of UP. We have done this through the Purvanchal and Bundelkhand expressways. Our next focus is the Ganga Expressway, through which we will connect east and west UP."

Not just construction, the state government is focusing on better monitoring of roads too. The state's public works department (PWD) has finalised a plan for digitised mapping and maintenance of roads. The state PWD minister Jitin Prasada wants to use technology for efficient monitoring, which would aid in the maintenance, of the state's vast road network of around 300,000 km. "We are focusing on GIS (global information system) mapping of all roads. Another step will be the digitisation of departmental records and making the data available through the Nigrani app. It will allow users to access details of all roads," says Prasada.

However, not everyone is rooting for the expressway drive. Former CM and Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav accused the government of rushing in to inaugurate "half-complete" expressways. "The hurried inauguration of the half-complete Bundelkhand Expressway shows that its design is *chalaau* (make-do)," he said in a statement. "Even with the proximity of the defence corridor, the BJP government could not construct an airstrip like the one made on the Agra-Lucknow Expressway during the Samajwadi Party government," he added. ■